

WHEN GOD IS SILENT

* Blue denotes power point slide

*Brown denotes instructions to the technician

TEXT: Matthew 26:36-46 (NKJV) *“Then Jesus came with them to a place called Gethsemane, and said to the disciples, “Sit here while I go and pray over there.”³⁷ And He took with Him Peter and the two sons of Zebedee, and He began to be sorrowful and deeply distressed.³⁸ Then He said to them, “My soul is exceedingly sorrowful, even to death. Stay here and watch with Me.”³⁹ He went a little farther and fell on His face, and prayed, saying, “O My Father, if it is possible, let this cup pass from Me; nevertheless, not as I will, but as You will.”⁴⁰ Then He came to the*

disciples and found them sleeping, and said to Peter, “What! Could you not watch with Me one hour? ⁴¹ Watch and pray, lest you enter into temptation. The spirit indeed is willing, but the flesh is weak.” ⁴² Again, a second time, He went away and prayed, saying, “O My Father, if this cup cannot pass away from Me unless^[a] I drink it, Your will be done.” ⁴³ And He came and found them asleep again, for their eyes were heavy. ⁴⁴ So He left them, went away again, and prayed the third time, saying the same words. ⁴⁵ Then He came to His disciples and said to them, “Are you still sleeping and resting? Behold, the hour is at hand, and the Son of Man is being betrayed into the hands of sinners. ⁴⁶ Rise, let us be going. See, My betrayer is at hand.”

INTRO: It would be great to think that every time we prayed, the answer would

come immediately. But, truth is, that's not always the case. In fact, quite the opposite is true; oftentimes God seems to be silent on the issues we face. I wish I could stand before you today and confidently declare, every single time you call upon the Lord He will answer right away. I cannot do that because it simply is not true. We must face the obvious; sometimes God is all too silent for our comfort! When this is the case we must exercise our right and responsibility to wait upon the Lord until He gives us His answer!

During a very difficult part of my life I remember sitting outside about three o'clock one morning looking up into the starry sky and saying to God, *"Why don't you say something? I don't care what the answer is I just want to hear you say something! Slap*

me if you would like, I just need to know you are actually hearing me!” There was nothing! I don’t think the stars even twinkled! It was deathly silent! I must tell you, I find those times to be most difficult! Soon after this experience I walked into a ministers meeting and one of the ministers whom I had never met came straight to me, never shook my hand or greeted me, he just started prophesying! Through that brother the Lord made me to know in unmistakable terms, He was there all the time and He had already devised a strategy for my victory. One should never mistake the silence of God for the disapproval of God upon ones life. There are many reasons for the silence of God and we are going to explore several of them.

In our text we find Jesus in the Garden of Gethsemane. This is nothing out of the

ordinary as I am sure He had been there many times prior. The Garden of Gethsemane was a popular destination but this trip to the Garden was without a doubt the most difficult visit he had ever made. The difficulty of this visit to the Garden had to do with the Cross, and the horrendous torture which awaited him the very next day. It is interesting to me that Jesus took with Him three of His inner circle, Peter, James, and John. I am reasonably sure Jesus included His three closest friends, so they could give Him support during the most difficult time of His earthly life. If He took them with Him for this reason they turned out to be another source of disappointment in an already bleak night. Jesus agonized (Intense struggle) until His sweat became as great drops of blood while the disciples slept

the night away as if they were laying on a Sealy or Posturepedic mattress!

The miracle of the incarnation of Christ is that He was 100% God and 100% man simultaneously. **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL I READ Matthew 26-39-44)**

Galatians 4:4 (KJV) ***“But when the fullness of time was come, God sent forth his Son, made of a woman, made under the law.”***

- God's Son became Mary's Baby...
- A child was born, but a son man was given....
- The Lion of the Tribe of Judah became a lamb slain from the foundation of the world... (From everlasting to everlasting – Eternal Priesthood after the order – Before Abraham was, I am)
- An equal to God became a lowly servant of all mankind...

- The Ancient of Days became an infant born in the stable of Bethlehem...
- The Omnipotent became a dependant life to be fed, clothed and nourished by human hands...
- He placed himself in the hands of man, that man might place himself in the hands of God... (Cast ourselves upon the mercies of God – His mercies are new every morning)
- On His Mothers side He became hungry, on His Fathers side He was the Bread of Life and could feed five thousand men with five biscuits and two pieces of fish...
- On His Mothers side he begged a woman of ill repute for a drink of water, on His Fathers side He created the oceans and the fountains of the deep...

- On His Mothers side He wept at the tomb of His friend Lazarus, on His Fathers side He called Lazarus back to life...
- On His Mothers side it was necessary to maintain hydration, on His Fathers side He offered water that would quench thirst for time and eternity...
- On His Mothers side He was thirty years old when He entered public ministry, on His Fathers side He was present when the morning stars sang together and the sons of God shouted for joy... (Where was Jesus from 12-30?)
- On His Mothers side He was thirty-three and one half years old, on His Fathers side He was the Ancient of Days...
- On His Mothers side He died an early death, on His Fathers side He abolished death...

- On His Mothers side He was buried in a borrowed tomb, on His Fathers side He is the resurrection and the life...
- On His Mothers side He was subject to His parents, on His Fathers side God gave Him a name above all other names...
- On His Mothers side He rode a donkey or walked everywhere He went, on His Fathers side He rides on the wings of the wind...
- On His Mothers side He used a candle to dispel the darkness of night, on His Fathers side He lit the world three days before He created the sun, moon and stars...
- On His Mothers side He could not light one room at a time, on His Fathers side He will be the light of a city that is built two thousand miles square...

- On His Mothers side He could only be in one place at a time, on His Fathers side He is omnipresent...
- On His Mothers side He had to rely upon the facts He could see, on His Fathers side He is omniscient...
- On His Mothers side He broke under the weight of the cross, on His Fathers side He is omnipotent...
- On His Mother's side He was a lamb led to His own slaughter, on His Fathers side He was the Lion of the Tribe of Judah...
- On His Mothers side He did not open His mouth in His own defense, on His Fathers side He possessed the power to call twelve legions of angels to His own rescue...
- On His Mothers side He tolerated injustice and aggression, on His Fathers side He treads out the wine press of the

wrath of God and breaks mighty armies across His knees...

- On His Mothers side He was Jesus, Mary's boy, on His Fathers side He is King of Kings and Lord of Lords...
- On His Mothers side He never had his name in lights, on His Fathers side He will reign forever...
- On His Mothers side He was never elected to high office, on His Fathers side He will rule over Heaven and Earth...
- On His Mothers side He was of no reputation, on His Fathers side every knee shall bow and every tongue shall confess He is Lord to the glory of God the Father...

As God, He knew the cross was the only way; as man He wondered if there might be

a better way. Matthew 26:39-44 (NKJV)

“He went a little farther and fell on His face, and prayed, saying, "O My Father, if it is possible, let this cup pass from Me; nevertheless, not as I will, but as You will." 40 Then He came to the disciples and found them asleep, and said to Peter, "What? Could you not watch with Me one hour? 41 Watch and pray, lest you enter into temptation. The spirit indeed is willing, but the flesh is weak." 42 Again, a second time, He went away and prayed, saying, "O My Father, if this cup cannot pass away from Me unless I drink it, Your will be done." 43 And He came and found them asleep again, for their eyes were heavy. 44 So He left them, went away again, and prayed the third time, saying the same words.”

It is here in the Garden that we get a momentary glimpse into the humanity of Jesus, He was struggling with what He knew lay in His pathway:

- Betrayal...
- False accusations...
- Wrongful imprisonment...
- A beating that would have killed a weaker man... (Young American who vandalized some cars in Singapore received a caning)
- A crown of thorns that was intended to bring humiliation...
- Nails in His hands and feet that were intended to hold Him to the cross until dead...
- A spear in the side just to make sure He did not survive the ordeal of the cross...
- The weight of a sinful world resting squarely on His shoulders...

We must NEVER forget, Jesus was crucified as the sinless son of man rather than the sinless Son of God.

Look at this, God's Son prayed three times and God was silent each time! It is astounding to me that Father God does not utter one word in the Garden! In this passage of Scripture there is not even a hint of direction from Heaven as to whether there would be a last minute substitute! Think of this, many times the silence of God is the answer of God; we must go through the difficulty rather than be delivered from it!

The mistake we often make is that we assume the silence of God is a deafening statement of His inattention to the activities

of our lives or worse, His disapproval of us on a personal level!

We should never mistake the silence of God for:

- Deafness...
- Unconcern...
- Inattention...
- Disapproval...

One of the most significant aspects of walking with God is to have a feel for His timing. Sometimes the silence of God is a matter of timing. ***Psalms 90:4 (NKJV) “For a thousand years in Your sight Are like yesterday when it is past, And like a watch in the night.” 2 Peter 3:8 (NKJV) “But, beloved, do not forget this one thing, that with the Lord one day is as a thousand years, and a thousand years as one day.”***

My question is, “*How could Jesus leave Heaven to come to earth and live as a mere mortal for thirty three and one half sinless years and then tolerate the silence of God on the eve of His crucifixion?*” What brought Jesus through the most difficult night of His life; a night when God was silent? **Hebrews 12:2 (NKJV)** “*Looking unto Jesus, the author and finisher of our faith, who for the joy that was set before Him endured the cross, despising the shame, and has sat down at the right hand of the throne of God.*” **Psalms 30:5 (NKJV)** “*For His anger is but for a moment, His favor is for life; Weeping may endure for a night, But joy comes in the morning.*” **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL END OF SERVICE)**

(END OF SERMON #1)

When God is silent...

I. FAITH IS BEING PUT TO THE TEST...

Hebrews 11:1 (NKJV) *“Now faith is the substance of things hoped for, the evidence of things not seen.”* Hebrews 11:6 (NKJV) *“But without faith it is impossible to please Him, for he who comes to God must believe that He is, and that He is a rewarder of those who diligently seek Him.”*

Faith is not belief without proof it is trust without reservation. (My experience meditating Hebrews 11:6) It is true at times when God is silent faith is being put to the test!

Because God was silent while Jesus was in the Garden, Jesus was placed in the position

of either calling for relief from his temporal circumstances which would have short circuited the redemption process, or setting an example of faith for road weary pilgrims to follow when the spiritual night is so dark one cannot see the next step to take.

If Jesus had caved under the pressure of the silence of the Father on the night before His crucifixion:

- The enemy would have defeated the Fathers answer for sin...
- The redemption process would have been back to square one...
- Mankind would have continued in sin without a Savior to call on...
- Evil would have continued to dominate Gods crowing creation, mankind...

- The world would probably have self destructed in a cesspool of sinful behavior...

The good news is that nothing of the sort transpired, Jesus persisted despite the silence of the Father! Jesus set a wonderful example of faith for every person who has ever experienced the Silence of God in moments of great trial.

The Father was not being disingenuous to Jesus in His hour of greatest trouble; He was allowing Jesus to set the bar of faith for His children to follow when they are not hearing a booming voice from the sky.

Most of us have programmed ourselves to believe that we should hear the voice of God before making any decision. I love it when

God speaks to me and leaves no doubt which direction He wants me to take but the truth of the matter is, it takes no faith to live like this!

Any of us can live a successful Christian life when God is telling us which socks to wear, what to eat, where to go, what to say! All one must do to live in this way is to be obedient, no faith needed! The will of God for His children is the development of faith! God would rather develop faith in our lives than to give us everything our little hearts desire. Sure, He wants us to have things but if He can develop faith we can be faithful when the battle is raging and the things are nowhere to be found!

Faith is developed when we face earth shaking, life altering, nail biting decisions,

and we do not hear one thing from God! He is silent on the issue! Have you ever been there? Are you there now? I am certainly not saying I prefer the silence of God, I don't, but how am I ever going to learn to live by faith when I allow myself to be paralyzed by the silence of God?

We often make the mistake of allowing our lives to be benched until we can get an answer from The Lord! This robs valuable time from the earthly journey of the child of God! Sure we need to hear from God but His silence should not automatically cause us to be disengaged while we wait for the thunder, the lightning, and a booming voice from the sky, saying, ***“Wear the blue socks, they will match your blue suit!”***

So what is going on when God is silent?
Faith is being put to the test!

This is what was going on with Jesus in the garden and there is a good chance this is what is going on with us when we are not hearing from God!

Jesus actually prayed, ***“If it is possible, let this cup pass from me.”*** It is here we see the humanity of Jesus. Jesus did not allow His humanity to stay engaged indefinitely, He said ***“Not my will but your will be done!”***

When God is silent we have a choice to make; we can allow the flesh to be engaged, which will be self-defeating; or we can allow faith to rise to the occasion, which will allow the Jesus in us to be engaged and

we will be able to *“Go from faith to faith,
and from victory to victory.”*

When this happens God will be allowed to make the rough place smooth, the crooked place straight, and the high place low! Faith is put to the test and when our faith has been *“Tried as by fire, it shall come forth as gold!”* William Newton Clarke said, *“Faith is the daring of the soul to go farther than it can see!”* **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)**

Patrick Overton said, *“When you have come to the edge of all that you know and are about to drop off into the darkness of the unknown, faith is knowing one of two things will happen: There will be something solid to land on; you will be taught to fly.”*

This is exactly what was going on with Jesus and He was setting an example for us that the Father can be trusted. In the Jesus world when His children are required to take a leap of faith He is going to give us a smooth landing or teach us to fly!

The Three Hebrew Children found this to be true: [Daniel 3:14-20 \(KJV\)](#)

“Nebuchadnezzar spake and said unto them, Is it true O Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, do not ye serve my gods, nor worship the golden image which I have set up? 15 Now if ye be ready that at what time ye hear the sound of the cornet, flute, harp , sackbut, psaltery, and dulcimer, and all kinds of musick, ye fall down and worship the image which I have made ; well: but if ye worship not, ye shall be cast the same hour into the midst of a burning

fiery furnace; and who is that God that shall deliver you out of my hands? 16 Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, answered and said to the king, O Nebuchadnezzar, we are not careful to answer thee in this matter. 17 If it be so, our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the burning fiery furnace, and he will deliver us out of thine hand, O king. 18 But if not, be it known unto thee, O king, that we will not serve thy gods, nor worship the golden image which thou hast set up . 19 Then was Nebuchadnezzar full of fury, and the form of his visage was changed against Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego: therefore he spake , and commanded that they should heat the furnace one seven times more than it was wont to be heated . 20 And he commanded the mighty men that were in his army to

bind Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego, and to cast them into the burning fiery furnace.”

Most of us have been taught that when the Three Hebrew Children responded to the threat of Nebuchadnezzar to throw them into the fire, they said ***“If you throw us in the fire, God will deliver us! But if He does not deliver us we will not bow down to your image.”*** We always seem to want to make sure God has an out, in case He does not get around to our deliverance!

Upon closer inspection, the ***“If it be so”*** in verse seventeen refers to the threat of the King to throw the Three Hebrew Children into the fire in verses fourteen and fifteen! The ***“But if not”*** in verse eighteen also refers to the threat of the King in verses

fourteen and fifteen! The Three Hebrew Children were actually saying, ***“If it be so that you throw us into the fire, God will deliver us! But if you do not throw us into the fire, we will not bow to your image.”*** In reality it was not the Three Hebrew Children who were in a dilemma, it was Nebuchadnezzar who was in the throes of a decision.

The Three Hebrew Children made their decision before they arrived at the event! I do not see anywhere in this passage where God said one word to them before or during their debate with the King! They knew what it would take to please their God and they just did it! The same should be true of us; we should not need to hear His voice to know what would please Him! We should just take the next logical step by faith!

Paul makes this statement in 2 Corinthians 2:8-10 (KJV) *“For we would not, brethren, have you ignorant of our trouble which came to us in Asia, that we were pressed out of measure, above strength, insomuch that we despaired even of life : 9 But we had the sentence of death in ourselves, that we should not trust in ourselves , but in God which raiseth the dead: 10 Who delivered us from so great a death, and doth deliver : in whom we trust that he will yet deliver us.”* God is in a constant state of rescue! (LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL END OF SERVICE)

It could be, when God is silent in the hour of crisis He is setting us up for a leap of faith whose upside potential is astronomical!

Remember, faith isn't faith until it's all we have!

(END OF SERMON #2)

II. GOD IS WORKING WHILE WE ARE WAITING...

The experience of Jesus in the garden of Gethsemane is disconcerting to many but we should never mistake the unresponsiveness of God for the inactivity of God! While Jesus prayed three times, God was certainly not unresponsive and He was anything but inactive.

Before the Garden experience of Jesus, the Father had set in motion a plan that was coming to pass even as Jesus was praying and God was unresponsive! **What was God doing while Jesus was praying and not**

getting an answer? **(PLACE ON THE
SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

He was enlisting Simon of Cyrene to carry
the cross of Christ...

He was placing it on the heart of Joseph of
Arimitheia to loan Jesus' family his tomb...

He was preparing the halls of Hell for a visit
from the dead Son of God...

He was getting the people in Paradise ready
for a Messiah they had anticipated for
centuries...

He was preparing a cemetery for a Sunday
morning resurrection celebration...

He was setting up Bethany's launching pad
for His Son's departure from earth...

He was making ready an upper room for the
outpouring of the Holy Spirit that would
energize believers with a world changing
power...

God was not in a state of inactivity, He was at work bringing to pass the completion of the plan of redemption!

How does this play out in our lives? Many times we plan our lives out and expect God to get involved. What we need to do is wait before the Lord until He gives direction for our lives!

Between a wish and a miracle lies waiting. Benjamin Franklin said, *“He that can have patience can have what he will.”* Romans 8:25 (NKJV) *“But if we hope for what we do not see, we eagerly wait for it with perseverance.”* Hebrews 11:36 (KJV) *“You have need of patience, so that after you have done the will of God, you may receive the promise.”*

We should never mistake the unresponsiveness of God for the inactivity of God! I want to make sure we understand this fully; **God is working while we are waiting! (PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)**

God was working while Noah was waiting! Noah preached one hundred twenty years without one raindrop and no converts outside his immediate family, but all along, God was in the process of sending a flood! God was working while Noah was praying, preaching and building an Ark to the saving of his house!

While the Children of Israel were praying for deliverance from Egyptian bondage, God was giving the mother of Moses power to conceive; having Pharaoh's daughter to fall in love with baby Moses; preparing Moses for ministry; and speaking to Moses from a

burning bush! God was working while the Children of Israel were collecting straw and making bricks!

While the Midianites were plundering the Israelites, God was causing Gideon to become a mighty man of valor! God was working while the Israelites were making an attempt to hold onto enough of their crops and livestock to support their families!

While the Israelites were waiting for deliverance from the Midianites, God was preparing Gideon to defeat the enemy with 300 men, armed only with empty pitchers, lanterns, trumpets, and a commitment to shouting!

While Elijah was hiding from Ahab and Jezebel, God was ordering fire from Heaven to prove the authenticity of the Prophets message! While Elijah was sitting around drowning in a sea of self-pity, God was

preparing a stream to give him water and ravens to air lift groceries to him every morning and evening! While Elijah was licking his wounds from Jezebels crowd, God was preparing a bankrupt widow to take care of him! God was working while Elijah was waiting!

While Stephen was being ostracized and eventually stoned for the sake of the Gospel, God was preparing a homecoming celebration in his honor! God was working while Stephen was suffering! God was making ready the city built foursquare while Stephen was forgiving those who were murdering him!

When we walk through the difficulties of our lives we must remember, God is working while we are waiting! Trying to understand the silence of God is like

straining to see through muddy water. The best thing is to be still and let the mud settle!

Some of us are much like Margaret Thatcher when she said, *"I am extraordinarily patient, provided I get my own way in the end."*

God is at work:

While marriages are falling apart...

While our children are on a trip to Stupidville...

While the economy is being challenged as never before...

While the doctor is delivering a bad report and saying there is no hope...

While the undertaker is letting our loved one down for the very last time...

God can never grant us the life He is waiting to give us until we cut loose the one we have planned for ourselves. God is committed to bless the life He has planned for us, not the one we planned for ourselves. **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** We must wait on God to direct our steps!

It often seems that our life is being flushed down the drain while our troubles or detractors are succeeding. Richard Rybolt said, *"There will be a time when loud-mouthed, incompetent people seem to be getting the best of you. When that happens, you only have to be patient and wait for them to self-destruct. It never fails."*

Listen to what the Word has to say about those who wait patiently for the Lord.

Psalms 27:14 (KJV) “Wait *on the LORD: be of good courage , and he shall strengthen thine heart: wait , I say, on the LORD.*”

Psalms 37:5-9 (KJV) “Commit thy way unto the LORD; trust also in him; and he shall bring it to pass . 6 And he shall bring forth thy righteousness as the light, and thy judgment as the noonday. 7 Rest in the LORD, and wait patiently for him: fret not thyself because of him who prospereth in his way, because of the man who bringeth wicked devices to pass . 8 Cease from anger, and forsake wrath: fret not thyself in any wise to do evil . 9 For evildoers shall be cut off : but those that wait upon the LORD, they shall inherit the earth.” (The world may control the wealth for now but the

righteous will rule on the earth for a thousand years – and then for eternity)

Psalms 37:34 (KJV) “Wait *on the LORD, and keep his way, and he shall exalt thee to inherit the land: when the wicked are cut off, thou shalt see it.*”

Psalms 145:15 (KJV) “*The eyes of all wait upon thee; and thou givest them their meat in due season.*”

Proverbs 20:22 (KJV) “*Say not thou, I will recompense evil; but wait on the LORD, and he shall save thee.*”

Proverbs 40:31 (KJV) “*But they that wait upon the LORD shall renew their strength; they shall mount up with wings as eagles;*

they shall run , and not be weary ; and they shall walk , and not faint .”

Lamentations 3:25-26 (KJV) *“The LORD is good unto them that wait for him, to the soul that seeketh him. 26 It is good that a man should both hope and quietly wait for the salvation of the LORD.”*

Just because we do not seeing God doing something does not mean He is inactive in our lives. While we are waiting God is working!

(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL END OF SERVICE)

III. WHEN GOD IS SILENT, WE MAY ALREADY KNOW THE ANSWER...

On the eve of His crucifixion Jesus prayed all night wrestling His flesh into conformity

to the will of the Father. On His Father's side Jesus knew from the start what must come to pass but on His mother's side He had to conform the will of the flesh to the will of the Father.

Some would question why Jesus looked for a relief route around the cross. The reason for this is that while He was one hundred percent God, He was also one hundred percent man! Look at what Jesus was facing: **(ALLOW SCENES FROM THE PASSION OF THE CHRIST TO PLAY ON THE SCREEN WHILE THE FOLLOWING BULLET POINTS ARE BEING MADE)**

He had supper with His disciples... This meal occurred in the Upper Room in Southwest Jerusalem and it was here He

revealed that one of His own would betray Him.

He faced a sleepless night in the Garden...

He prayed while His closest friends slept.

He agonized before the Father in prayer

until His sweat became as great drops of

blood... The name "***Gethsemane***" comes

from the Hebrew word Gat Shumanim, and

means "*oil press*." I think the name of this

place is significant because it appears to me

that while Jesus was agonizing before the

Father, His spirit was under the most severe

attack of His earthly life. This was spiritual

warfare! His spirit was assaulted to the

point that three times He said, "***If it be***

possible, let this cup pass from me." It is in

this crucial, pivotal time that Jesus cries,

"Not my will, but thine be done." Though

some folks would like to argue that Jesus

sweat becoming like blood drops is

figurative, medical science say's this is possible but only when a person is encountering a life threatening degree of stress. The medical term for this is "*Hemohydrosis*" or "*Hematidrosis.*" This phenomenon occurs when the capillaries around the sweat pores become fragile and leak blood into the sweat. Thus, human sweat becomes mixed with blood and great sweat-drops of blood occur.

He was betrayed by Judas and then deserted by all the disciples...

He was arrested in the Garden... Jesus was arrested immediately following an all night prayer meeting; no time to freshen up or catch His breath He was incarcerated on the heels of an agonizing all night prayer meeting.

Following His arrest, He was brought back to the palace of the High Priest... It was

here that He was interrogated by Annas, a former High Priest and Caiaphas, Annas' son-in-law.

He was then tried by the Sanhedrin, and found guilty of blasphemy... This trial was based on His proclamation of being the Son of God.

He was sentenced to die for a crime He never committed... I wonder where the ACLU was???

He was sent to Pontius Pilate at the Antonia Fortress... This was done because only the Romans were able to execute criminals.

Pilate did not find fault with Him...

Because Pilate was a people pleaser He treated Jesus as the political hot potato He had become.

Pilate sent Jesus to Herod who did not want to get involved...

Herod sent Jesus back to Pilate...

Pilate caved in to the pressure of the crowd and ordered Jesus to be tortured and crucified...

Jesus was beaten with thirty-nine stripes...

The whip He was beaten with had pieces of metal and broken pieces of glass and pottery sowed into the ends of it!

Jesus was required to carry His cross from Pilates Judgment Hall to Golgotha... It is believed the cross of Jesus weighed one hundred twenty-five pounds and He carried it for two and one half miles!

Friends, this was what Jesus was dealing with in the Garden, while the Father was absolutely silent! In fact **Jesus thought the Father had forsaken Him!** Have you ever felt that way? Jesus cried from the cross, ***Eli, Eli lama-sa-bach-tha-ni. Which being interpreted is My God, My God, why has***

thou forsaken Me?” We know the Father did not forsake Jesus and we know God is not going to forsake us, but it sure feels that way from time to time!

If the Father said nothing from the Garden to the cross, what was going on? The Father did not need to say anything because the decision concerning the cross had long since been settled! There was only one path to redemption: through the sacrifice of the sinless son of man!

Could it be that if we are not hearing from God, we already know the answer? It may not be the answer we want to hear, but the silence of God may very well be the answer of God!

Because of the grave illness of their brother, Mary and Martha called for their friend Jesus. Jesus did not respond until Lazarus had been dead four day's! This could really get a person ticked off!!

When Jesus finally showed up, listen to how He addresses the situation. John 11:14-15 (NKJV) "Then Jesus said to them plainly, "Lazarus is dead and I am glad for your sakes that I was not there, that you may believe. Nevertheless let us go to him."

Martha was not impressed! She said to Jesus ***"If you had been here, Lazarus would not have died."*** This is a scathing accusation against anyone, but this is Jesus she is talking to!

Remember, when God allows us to take a step of faith into the unknown, He will create a soft place for our landing or He is going to teach us to fly! Jesus was not attempting to be disingenuous to the sisters from Bethany by not showing up when He was needed, He was preparing them for a faith flight!

Mary and Martha were not in the mood for flying and if they had been they sure would not have wanted to fly coach which sure seemed like what they were doing! (How to get a seat to yourself on Southwest)

Have you ever had a situation that was so far out of hand that you felt God had let you down with His commitment to silence? Sometimes when God is silent, we already have our answer!

This is not the end of this scandal! While Martha was vocal with her feelings about the silence of Jesus in the most traumatic time of their lives, the Bible says “*Mary stayed in the house.*” Jesus was not the only one who could be silent. Mary turned the tables on Jesus and gave Him a little taste of His own medicine: The silent treatment!

Jesus did not come when He was called for because He knew He was going to resurrect Lazarus from the dark tomb of death he was in. Through the resurrection of Lazarus, He was going to ratchet up the faith of His followers! The resurrection of Lazarus was about to launch the followers of Jesus to a new level of faith where they could take new

territory; whip new devils; and fly at new altitudes!

When God is silent it is often because the outcome has already been decided and the waiting period is the result of a very deliberate God working in the lives of intensely desperate, powerfully impatient, terribly misguided people!

While some of us can accept the fact, God is very deliberate while we are waiting, the outcome has already been decided, what we really would like to know is [what takes God so long to reveal His answer to us?](#)

I think the answer to this all-encompassing question could be that He has bound Himself to work with people who possess free moral agency. Why God allowed for

free will is the one question I would like to have an answer to!

This one thing has caused all of us more trouble than we would like to admit.

Because God has given humankind the power of choice and our prayers often involve other individuals, God must work with the free moral agency of those individuals to bring about our answer and His will. This takes time, lots of time, even if you are God!

When God is silent He is oftentimes revealing the answer, we must go through the battle!

In those times when God is silent, we must never mistake his silence for a lack of interest! We should never assume that

because He has not spoken He does not hear our cry! When God is not talking it is often a matter of timing!

The thing that allowed Jesus to withstand the difficulty of the last forty-eight hours of His human life is that He knew Sunday was coming! Hebrews 12:2 (KJV) ***“Looking unto Jesus, the author and finisher of our faith, who for the joy that was set before Him endured the cross, despising the shame, and has sat down at the right hand of the throne of God.”***

Please allow me to ask you:

Have you had a Gethsemane?

Have you prayed the night through?

Have you shed tears of agony when no hope was in view?

Have you prayed, if it be thy will let this cup pass from me?

Has God been silent in a time when you desperately needed to hear His voice?

I want us to leave here assured of one thing;
When God is silent and our faith is allowed to develop...

When God is silent and He is working behind the scenes...

When God's silence is His answer and we must go through the fiery trial of persecution...

When God is silent He will go with us and bring us out in great victory! **(LEAVE ON SCREEN UNTIL NEXT SLIDE)** I want you to know that the blackness of the starless sky cannot hold back the dawn! If God has been silent in a most inconvenient time in your life, I have His answer for you today! Psalm 30:5 (KJV) ***“His anger is but for a moment, His favor is for life;***

***Weeping may endure for a night, but joy**
comes in the morning.*

Isaiah 43:2 (KJV) “***When you pass through the waters, I will be with you; And through the rivers, they shall not overflow you.***

When you walk through the fire, you shall not be burned,

Nor shall the flame scorch you.”

Lamentations 3:25-26 (NKJV) “The Lord is good to those who wait for Him, To the soul who seeks Him. 26 It is good that one should hope and wait quietly For the salvation of the Lord.”

Just because we do not witness God doing something, does not mean his is inactive.

While we are waiting God is working!

Paul makes this statement in 2 Corinthians 1:8-10 (NKJV) “For we do not want you to be ignorant, brethren, of our trouble which came to us in Asia: that we were burdened

beyond measure, above strength, so that we despaired even of life. 9 Yes, we had the sentence of death in ourselves, that we should not trust in ourselves but in God who raises the dead, 10 who delivered us from so great a death, and does deliver us; in whom we trust that He will still deliver us.”

God is in a constant state of rescue!

It could be when God is silent in the hour of crisis, He is setting us up for a leap of faith whose upside potential is astronomical!

Remember, Faith is not faith until it has been tested and it is all we have!

CONCLUSION:

Recipe for staying the course when God is silent: **(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME THEN LEAVE ALL ON THE SCREEN UNTIL THE END OF THE SERVICE)**

Extra large portion of dependence on God...

Apply equal measure of trust in the Lord...

Stir in a pinch or two of faith for each situation...

Mix thoroughly with enough persistence for good consistency...

Let everything settle until God speaks...